

04 - The Davis Polk Matter Story Template

A Case Study Format Optimized for SEO and GEO

Why This Template Exists

Davis Polk closes some of the most significant transactions in US corporate law. That experience is the firm's most valuable proof of expertise — and almost none of it is visible to AI engines.

The reason is format, not confidentiality.

A tombstone is a receipt — it records a transaction but provides no context AI engines can extract as expertise evidence. It names parties, states a dollar value, and ends. It answers no question a GC buyer would actually ask.

Deloitte publishes case studies naming "a Fortune 500 pharmaceutical company" without ever identifying the client. BCG publishes "client impact" stories describing a challenge, an approach, and a quantified outcome without disclosing confidential information. Both face confidentiality obligations comparable to Davis Polk's. Neither lets those obligations prevent matter storytelling at the level of aggregation that generates AI citations.

This template enables publication without client identification, optimizes for GEO, serves dual purpose (human readers and AI crawlers), and scales across all practice areas.

The Seven-Element Structure Element 1: The Matter Headline

Format: [Deal Type] + [Sector] + [Key Challenge or Distinction]

Maximum: 12 words. Must answer a query a GC would actually ask.

Tombstone (AI-invisible)	GEO-Optimized Headline
"Representation of [Client] in \$4.2B acquisition of [Target]"	"Hostile Takeover Defense: Pharmaceutical Company Contested Acquisition"
"[Client] IPO on the NYSE"	"Dual-Class Structure IPO: Technology Company Capital Markets Debut"

"Restructuring of [Client] in Chapter 11"	"Pre-Packaged Chapter 11 Restructuring: Energy Sector Debt Reorganization"
"[Client] FCPA investigation and resolution"	"DOJ/SEC Parallel FCPA Investigation: Global Manufacturing Company Resolution"

Element 2: The Matter Type Tags

Three to five taxonomy labels displayed below the headline, each linked to the relevant practice and industry page.

Category	Example Tags
Deal/Matter Type	Cross-Border M&A · Hostile Defense · Going-Private · Carve-Out · Chapter 11 · IPO · High-Yield Offering · SPAC · Regulatory Investigation
Industry Sector	Financial Services · Life Sciences · Technology · Energy · Private Equity · Real Estate · Media & Entertainment · Sports
Jurisdiction/Regulatory Body	SEC · DOJ · FTC · CFPB · Federal Reserve · European Commission · UK CMA · Multi-Jurisdictional
Deal Complexity Signal	Cross-Border · Contested · Novel Structure · First-of-Kind · Precedent-Setting · Multi-Regulator

Element 3: The Matter Summary (The "First 30%")

Format: 100–150 words. Three sentences maximum. Structure: Situation → Complexity → Significance.

Rule: Open with deal type and sector, NOT with "Davis Polk represented..."

[Deal type] in the [sector] sector involving [key complexity]. The matter required [specific legal challenge]. [One sentence on significance.]

Example:

Hostile takeover defense for a publicly traded pharmaceutical company facing an unsolicited all-cash offer from a larger strategic acquirer in the same sector. The defense required simultaneous engagement with SEC tender offer rules, state corporate law requirements in two jurisdictions, and a proxy contest timeline compressed to 23 days. The matter established a new precedent for the use of shareholder rights plans in combination with a market check process under accelerated timelines.

Element 4: The Situation

Format: 150–250 words. Two to three paragraphs. Client identified only by sector, size range, and general description.

Anonymization Framework:

Client Type	Acceptable Format
Named public company	"A Fortune 500 pharmaceutical company" / "A Nasdaq-listed technology firm with annual revenue exceeding \$3 billion"
Named private company	"A privately held energy company operating in 12 US states"

PE-backed company	"A portfolio company of a leading global private equity firm"
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Client Type	Acceptable Format
Financial institution	"A US regional bank" / "A global investment bank"
Regulator (counterparty)	Named — regulators are public entities

Element 5: The Davis Polk Approach

Format: 200–350 words. Named sub-section headers for each distinct phase or discipline.

Sub-section header examples: Regulatory Strategy · Transaction Structuring · Negotiation Framework · Multi-Jurisdictional Coordination · Creditor Negotiations · Defense Preparation

Named attorney guidance: If the supervising partner consents: *"Led by [Partner Name — inserted upon consent], [Title], with support from [name/title]."* This creates the attorney → matter → practice connection AI engines require for individual expert attribution.

Element 6: The Outcome

Format: 100–150 words. Include at least one specific, quantified fact.

Examples:

- "Transaction closed in 14 days from public announcement"
- "Pre-packaged restructuring confirmed in 47 days — one of the fastest Chapter 11 completions for a debt restructuring exceeding \$2 billion in the Southern District of New York"
- "All regulatory approvals obtained in [X] jurisdictions within [Y] months, with no required divestitures"

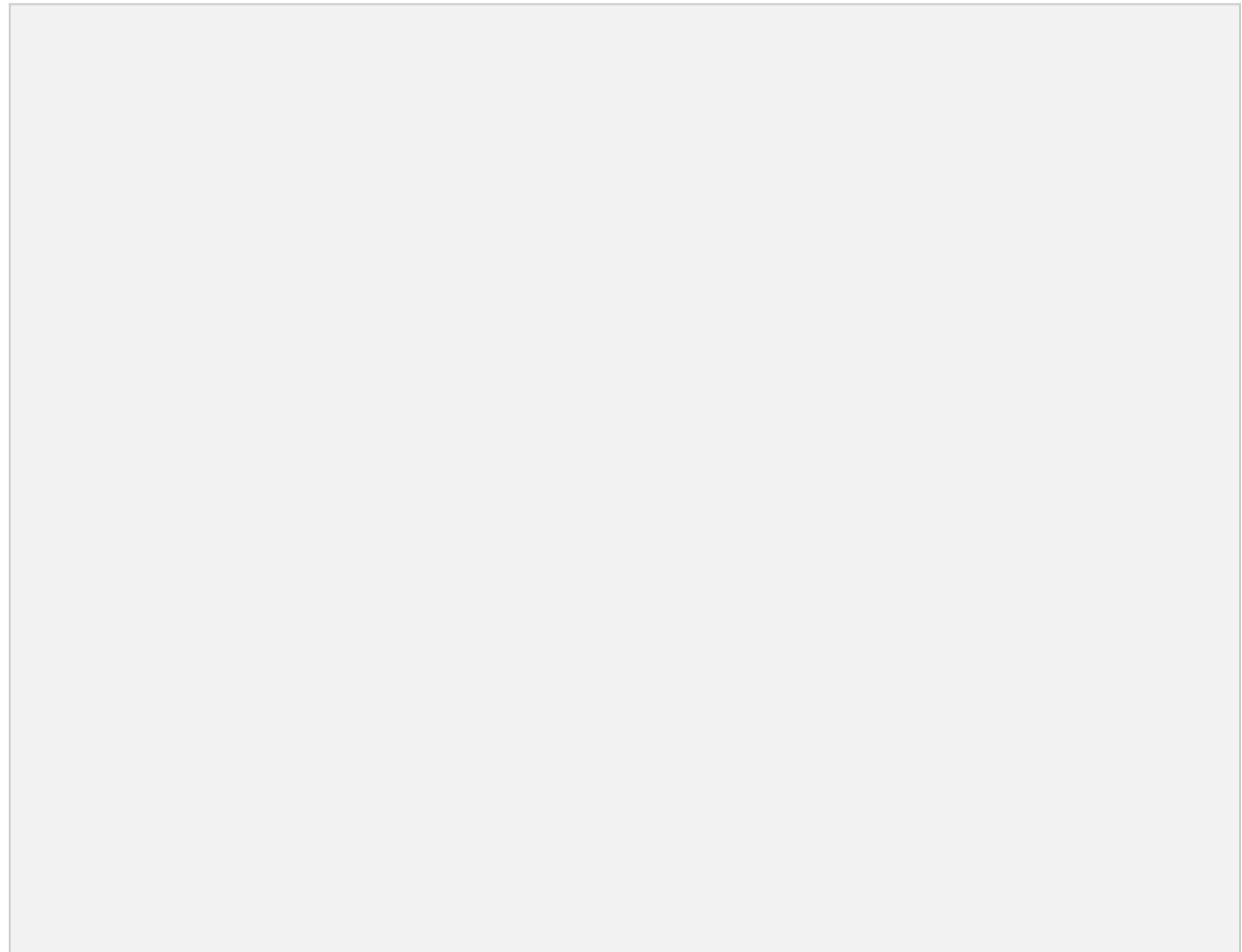
If a specific number is unavailable: "The transaction structure was adopted as a model for subsequent [deal type] transactions by the acquiring firm's counsel."

Element 7: Related Resources

Three to five cross-links:

- **Related Practice Areas:** Links to relevant practice pages
- **Related Insights:** Links to related client alerts or thought leadership
- **Related Industries:** Links to relevant industry pages

Schema Block (Hand Directly to Web Development Team)



If no named partner consent: use "author": [{"@type": "Organization", "name": "Davis Polk & Wardwell LLP"}]. Named author schema is strongly preferred; anonymous organization-level schema is meaningfully better than no schema at all.

Page URL Structure

davispolk.com/matters/[industry-slug]/[deal-type-slug]/[brief-descriptor]

Examples:

- davispolk.com/matters/pharmaceutical/hostile-defense/cross-border-acquisition-defense
- davispolk.com/matters/energy/restructuring/chapter-11-pre-packaged-reorganization
- davispolk.com/matters/technology/ipo/dual-class-structure-capital-markets

The Three Intake Questions

Ask within 14 days of matter closing, triggered by the matter management system.

1. "What made this matter harder than it looked?"

The complexity question. Partners answer readily — it invites them to describe their own judgment and skill. Becomes the core of Elements 3 and 5.

2. "Is there a number we can use?"

The outcome question. Closing timeline, regulatory approval duration, creditor recovery percentage, deal premium above initial offer. If no specific number: "Is there a comparison we can make? Faster than average? Fewer conditions than typical?" A comparative claim is almost always available. Becomes Element 6.

3. "Would you put your name on this?"

The attribution question. Explain in one sentence why it matters: named attorney attribution increases the probability that AI engines cite their individual expertise when GCs search for outside counsel in this practice area.

The intake moment: Build the request into the closing workflow — when the matter management system processes closing paperwork. Not as a separate marketing ask. That friction removal is what distinguishes firms with functioning matter libraries from firms with empty ones.

Confidentiality Protocol

Gate	Reviewer	Question
Client consent	Supervising partner	Has the client been informed that an anonymized matter description will be published?
Anonymization check	Practice group coordinator	Is the client identifiable from the description?
Identifiability check	Practice group coordinator	Is the client identifiable from the combination of sector, size, geography, and timing — even without their name appearing?
Confidential information check	General Counsel review	Does the description disclose any non-public information?
Named attorney consent	Each named attorney	Has the attorney reviewed and approved their attribution?

CMS backstop: The Davis Polk website automatically flags content containing restricted client names before publication. This catches named references that survive the drafting process, but it is not a substitute for the identifiability check above — a client can be recognizable without being named. Authors should complete anonymization before submission; the CMS flag is a safety net, not a clearance step.

Safe harbor standard: A matter story is publishable without client consent when it passes all four gates above and no client can be identified from the published description. This is the same standard Deloitte, BCG, and McKinsey apply to their own client case studies.

Matter Library Build Plan

Phase 1 — Pilot (Months 1–2): 10 matter stories across 5 practice areas (2 per practice). Target: M&A, Capital Markets, Restructuring, Regulatory/Enforcement, Litigation.

Phase 2 — Expansion (Months 3–6): 3 matter stories per practice area per quarter — 30 new stories in 90 days. Assign a marketing team member as matter story editor.

Phase 3 — Integration (Months 7–12): Surface matter stories on all relevant practice pages, industry pages, and attorney bio pages via a "Representative Matters" cross-link module. Build a searchable library filterable by industry, deal type, practice area, and year.

Target volume for meaningful AI citation impact: 50–75 structured, schema-marked matter stories. Davis Polk closes hundreds of matters a year. Reaching 50 stories over 12 months means less than one story per week across the entire firm.

Full Completed Example

CONSTRUCTED ILLUSTRATION — This example uses no real client, matter, or transaction data. All facts, figures, timelines, and outcomes are fabricated for format demonstration purposes only. Do not cite or circulate as a real Davis Polk matter.

Cross-Border Hostile Acquisition Defense in the Pharmaceutical Sector

Hostile Defense · Pharmaceutical & Life Sciences · SEC / Delaware · Contested · Cross-Border

Hostile takeover defense for a publicly traded pharmaceutical company facing an unsolicited all-cash offer from a larger European acquirer seeking immediate board representation and control. The defense required simultaneous coordination across SEC tender offer rules, Delaware corporate law, and EU Merger Regulation timelines under a 23-day proxy window. The matter resulted in a negotiated outcome that preserved existing management, increased total shareholder value at a premium above the initial offer, and established a new precedent for deployment of shareholder rights plans in combination with an accelerated market check under activist pressure.

Situation

A Nasdaq-listed pharmaceutical company with annual revenues exceeding \$4 billion received an unsolicited public offer from a European strategic acquirer seeking a controlling stake, arriving simultaneously with a nomination notice for board seats. The target company's board faced a fiduciary landscape complicated by a recent earnings disappointment, a depressed share price, and three activist funds that had collectively accumulated a 12% stake in the preceding quarter.

Davis Polk was retained within 48 hours of the public announcement. The initial challenge was assessing the credibility of the acquirer's financing commitment, the regulatory approval timeline in both the US and EU, and the likelihood of the proxy contest succeeding given the existing activist ownership profile.

The Davis Polk Approach

Regulatory Strategy

Davis Polk coordinated with the SEC's Division of Corporation Finance to confirm the applicable tender offer timeline under Rule 14d-9 and assess whether the acquirer's simultaneous proxy solicitation violated the all-holders rule. Separate communications with the Delaware Court of Chancery established the framework for expedited relief should the acquirer proceed without full compliance.

Transaction Structuring / Defense Architecture

Davis Polk structured a shareholder rights plan with a 15% threshold calibrated to the activist ownership profile, paired with a market check process coordinated with three qualified strategic acquirers to establish a credible competitive process.

Multi-Jurisdictional Coordination

EU Merger Regulation Phase I review was projected at 25 working days — creating a structural timeline advantage. Davis Polk coordinated with European counsel to formally trigger the EU review process, extending the effective defense window.

Led by [Partner Name — inserted upon consent], M&A Practice, with support from the Davis Polk Capital Markets and Regulatory teams.

Outcome

The matter concluded 31 days from initial engagement with a negotiated transaction at a 22% premium to the original offer — achieved without any board seat concessions and without a shareholder vote. EU Merger Regulation Phase I review was completed without conditions. All three activist funds tendered their shares at the negotiated price. The 31-day resolution timeline has been cited in academic commentary on hostile defense strategy as a model for rights plan deployment in combination with an accelerated market check.

Related Practice Areas: M&A Practice · Capital Markets Practice · Securities Regulation & Enforcement

Related Industries: Pharmaceutical & Life Sciences

Related Insights: [Davis Polk Client Alert: Delaware Court Confirms Shareholder Rights Plan Parameters] · [Davis Polk M&A Market Monitor: Hostile Activity Trends Q1 2026]

Working editorial tool. Intended users: Davis Polk marketing team, practice group coordinators, and the partners and associates who review and approve matter stories before publication.